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General Knowledge
Modern History

STUDY NOTES

Expansion of British East India Company
- Battle of Plassey and Buxar

Expansion of East India Company - Battle of Plassey & Buxar

"A Turning Point in British Rule in India"

Introduction

- The British East India Company was established in **1600** as a trading entity but gradually expanded its role in Indian politics and administration.
- By the early 18th century, the Company aimed to consolidate its economic and military power in India, with Bengal as a focal region for its resources and trade routes.
- The **battles of Plassey and Buxar** marked significant turning points, allowing the Company to transition from a trading entity to a ruling power.
- **In the Mughal Period:** Bengal was the most fertile and richest province of the Mughal Empire and included present-day Bangladesh and the states of Bihar and Odisha.
- The authoritative powers of the province lay in the hands of the Nawab of Bengal.
- Bengal was economically important for its famous **textiles, silk, and saltpetre**. Exports from Bengal to Europe comprised saltpetre, rice, indigo, pepper, sugar, silk, cotton textiles, handicrafts, etc.
- Bengal became the first kingdom to be occupied by the British in India. The East India Company carried on a profitable trade with this province.

- **Conflicts among Nawabs and the British:**

- The special privileges granted to the British Company were strongly opposed by the Nawabs of Bengal, as they resulted in significant losses for the provincial treasury.
- **Siraj-ud-Daulah became the Nawab of Bengal in 1756,** inheriting a vast and wealthy region that included **Bengal, Bihar, and parts of Orissa.**
- The East India Company had been expanding its influence through political manoeuvring and military strength. Their growing presence in Bengal threatened the local administration, and Siraj viewed the Company's ambitions with suspicion.
- Consequently, the tension between British commercial interests and the Bengal government became the primary cause of conflict between the two.
- Although modern historians question the accuracy of the account, the story was used by the British as a justification for retaliation and an excuse to challenge Siraj's rule.
- As a result, the British sought a "puppet" Nawab on the throne of Bengal, someone who would willingly provide them with trade concessions and other privileges, thereby allowing the British to establish their indirect but ultimate control over the province.
- Many of Siraj's courtiers, including **Mir Jafar**, the commander of his army, were discontent with his rule.
- The British exploited these internal divisions and bribed several key figures within Siraj's administration, promising them positions of power in return for their support.
- The conflicts and confrontations culminated in the Battle of Plassey on June 23**, 1757. The British, led by Robert Clive, managed to defeat Siraj-ud-Daulah with the help of Mir Jafar's betrayal.**

Battle of Plassey (1757)

- **The Battle of Plassey was fought in 1757 in the Plassey (or Palashi) region of West Bengal, on the east of the Bhagirathi River.**
- Troops of the British East India Company, led by **Robert Clive**, came up against the forces of **Siraj-ud-Daulah,** the last independent Nawab of Bengal, and his French Ally.

- This battle is often termed as th**e 'decisive event'** which became the source of the ultimate rule of the British in India.
- The battle occurred during the reign late reign of the Mughal empire (called later Mughal Period).
- **Mughal emperor Alamgir-II was ruling the empire when the Battle of Plassey took place.**

- ## Causes of the Battle of Plassey
  - The rampant misuse of the trade privileges given to the British by the Nawab of Bengal.
  - **Non-payment of tax and duty** by the workers of the British East India Company
  - Fortification of Calcutta by the British without the Nawab's permission
  - Misleading Nawab on various fronts by the British
  - An asylum was provided to **Nawab's enemy Krishna Das**

- ## The capture of Fort William:
  - It is one of the immediate causes of the Battle of Plassey.
  - Following the **Seven-years war**, the British were building military operations against the French.
  - They refused to halt these operations against the French.
  - Siraj-ud-daula attacked the British in Fort William in Calcutta and captured the Fort.
  - **The British army turned against Siraj-ud-Dawla to retaliate.**
- ## Black Hole tragedy:
  - **The Nawab, Siraj-ud-Daula is said to have imprisoned 146 Englishmen in a small chamber.**
  - **It was told that 123 out of 146 Englishmen died due to suffocation.**
  - **This aroused the anger of the Englishmen.**
- ## Battle of Plassey – Combat
  - In March 1757, the French settlement of Chandernagore was captured by the English. This was the ignition point of the Battle of Plassey.
  - **Robert Clive bribed Mir Jafar, the commander-in-chief of Siraj-ud-Daula,** and promised to make him the Nawab of Bengal in return for his service to the company.
  - The English strengthened their position still by forming a secret alliance with the traitors of the Nawab.
  - Siraj-ud-Daula along with his French allies had 50000 soldiers, 40 canons, and 10 war elephants.
  - All these were defeated by the handful of soldiers the British.
  - Thus at the end of the Battle of Plassey, Siraj-ud-Daula was captured and murdered by

Mir Jafar's son Miran.

- After the Battle, the English captured Bengal and gradually monopolized the trades in Bengal.

Battle of Plassey – Significance

- The Battle of Plassey laid the foundation for the British empire in India.
- Military supremacy over Bengal was established by the British.
- The French settlements in Bengal were captured.
- **Mir Jafar became the Nawab of Bengal.**
- A resident was posted in the Nawab's court.
- Mir Jaffar awarded the British with the grant of zamindari of 24 Parganas and a huge sum of money for their service in the Battle of Plassey.
- The victory in the Battle of Plassey in 1757 increased the prestige of the British.
- The roles of Siraj-ud-Daulah, Robert Clive, and Mir Jafar in the conflict between the Nawabs of Bengal and the British East India Company:

Person	Role	Significance in the Conflict
Siraj-ud-Daulah	**Nawab of Bengal (1756-1757)**	Opposed the British East India Company's influence and privileges in Bengal. His resistance led to the Battle of Plassey, where he was defeated.
Robert Clive	**British East India Company officer and key strategist**	Led the British forces against Siraj-ud-Daulah at the Battle of Plassey, securing British victory through military strategy and alliances.
Mir Jafar	**Commander in Siraj-ud-Daulah's army, later appointed as Nawab by the British**	Secretly allied with the British during the Battle of Plassey, betraying Siraj-ud-Daulah. His cooperation helped the British secure control over Bengal.

Battle Of Buxar (1764)

- **The Battle of Buxar took place in the northeast region of the country on 22 October 1764.**
- It was one of the decisive battles of Indian history.
- It was the Battle of Buxar which earned the British East India Company control over **Bengal and Bihar.**
- The seeds for this significant battle were sown soon after the Battle of Plassey. The Battle of Buxar was fought between the B**ritish East India Company's force led by Hector Munro** and the combined forces of **Shah Alam II (the Mughal emperor), Shuja-Ud-Daula (Nawab of Awadh), and Mir Qasim (Nawab of Bengal).** The battle came to an end in 1765 with the victory of the Company and the surrender of Shah Alam II.

Causes of the Battle of Buxar

- **Mir Qasim,** a strong and efficient ruler determined to make the affairs of the state better, shifted the **capital from Murshidabad in Calcutta to Munger in Bihar in 1762.**
- He declared himself to be an independent ruler. This angered the British as they wanted him to be their puppet ruler.
- He also hired **foreign country experts to train his army** as their strength was very necessary for Mir Qasim to maintain his independence.
- British East India Company officials **misused the Farman of 1717** and Dastak for their personal gain.
- This act led Mir Qasim to take the extreme step of abolishing all duties on International trade, which gave an edge to his own subjects in trade and kept the British in check.
- He treated both the British merchants and Indian Merchants equally and thus denied any special treatment to the East India Company, causing them huge revenue losses.
- The British demanded preferential treatment over all others.
- All these factors, especially the tussle over the transit duty, resulted in the outbreak of war in 1763.

Roles of Participants in the Battle of Buxar

Participants	Respective Roles
Mir Qasim	Nawab of Bengal; Offended by British terms; Formed an alliance against the British

Shuja-ud-Daulah	Nawab of Awadh; Formed a confederacy with Mir Qasim and Shah Alam II
Shah Alam II	Mughal Emperor; Wished to drive the English out of Bengal
Hector Munro	British Army Major; Led the British forces in the Battle of Buxar
Robert Clive	British East India Company official; Negotiated treaties with Shuja-ud-Daulah and Shah Alam II after the British victory

- ## Result of Battle Of Buxar

- **Mir Qasim** abandoned his troops and escaped from the battlefield.
- **Shah Alam-II and Shuja-Ud-Daula** surrendered to the British.
- The English became the uncontested rulers of Northern India and announced themselves as contenders for power and supremacy throughout India.
- **Robert Clive**, who played an important role in the battle, signed two important treaties with Shuja-Ud-Daula and Shah Alam-II called the **Treaty of Allahabad in 1765.**
- After the war, Mir Jafar was again made the puppet ruler by the English.
- Mir Jafar also **surrendered the districts of Burdwan, Midnapore, and Chittagong** to the English to maintain their army.
- The British traders were also granted preferential duty exemptions on trade in Bengal except on salt, with a duty of 2 percent.
- After the demise of Mir Jafar, his minor son Nizam-Ud-Daula was made the emperor. However, the British maintained the real power of administration by appointing Naib-Subedar of their choice.
- Later, Nizam-Ud-Daula became a pensioner of the British by signing a treaty with RS.53 lakhs per year.
- In **1772**, the **British East India Company completely abolished the pension scheme** and took over the administration of Bengal directly.

Treaty Of Allahabad

Lord Robert Clive signed two important treaties with Shuja-Ud-Daula and Shah Alam-II at Allahabad after the Battle of Buxar in 1765.

The First treaty of Allahabad with Shuja-Ud-Daula, the Nawab of Awad

- Shuja-Ud-Daula was forced to cede Allahabad and Kara to Shah Alam-II.
- He also agreed to pay an indemnity of Rs.50 lakhs to the East India Company.
- His full possession of the estate was handed over to Zamindar of Banaras, Balwant Singh.
- Even though the Shuja-Ud-Daula was defeated, Awadh was never annexed but left as a buffer state to protect against foreign invasion.

Second treaty of Allahabad with Shah Alam

- Shah Alam was to reside under the Company's protection at Allahabad, which he got from Shuja-Ud-Daula under the first treaty of Allahabad.
- The districts of Bihar and Orissa were to be ceded to the company.
- Shah Alam had to provide a Farman granting Diwani rights of Bengal to the company. In return for the Nizamat function, that is, defence, police, and justice administration, Shah Alam had to pay Rs.53 Lakhs per annum to the Company for the Districts of Bihar, Orissa, and Bengal.

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